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72 | **'DIOR GOES TO INDIA'**, 'Dior's Gateway to India', and 'Dior Celebrates Indian Artisans' were just some of the headlines that splashed across international news outlets earlier this year, when French *maison* Christian Dior showcased its Pre-Fall collection at Mumbai's iconic Gateway of India. Making it all possible was

Karishma Swali, the Managing and Creative Director of Mumbai-based atelier Chanakya International and the Chanakya School of Craft, which specialises in embroidery and craft that adorns international haute couture.

Swali's father, Vinod Shah, set up Chanakya in 1986 with 22 master artisans to share India's finest craftsmanship and artisanal legacy with the world, and she joined the family enterprise 26 years ago. Today, Chanakya's client list includes some of the biggest names in luxury. Apart from Dior, there's Fendi, Prada, Valentino, Celine, and Saint Laurent. The atelier's relationship with Dior itself goes back to 2016, when Maria Grazia Chiuri took over as the French brand's Creative Director. "We work extensively with many clients in both the LVMH and Kering groups," says Swali.

It was during an internship at Italian luxury brand Alberta Ferretti in the mid-1990s that Swali realised the importance of handicrafts. "The Italians are so proud of it. If a shoe upper is being moulded by hand, they are like, you know it's handmade. In India, everything is handmade. It is so much a part of us that sometimes we don't realise how precious it is," says Swali. "My one year in Italy really made an impression, and I realised that I wanted to spend my time exploring craft and contribute to making it a global language," she adds.

Today, Chanakya has over 1,000 master artisans and is a name to be reckoned with in the couture space internationally. For the Dior show, besides the embroidery on all the runway looks, Chanakya created a 46-foot embroidered installation, or a *toran*, which took 382 craftspeople over six months.



WIDENING REACH

With the Dior show out of the way, Swali is focussed now on widening the reach of the Chanakya School of Craft, which she co-founded with Chiuri in 2016 to train more artisans in Indian crafts and techniques. She is particularly keen on helping women become master artisans. "Generationally, in India, craft is taught only from father to son. And even though it is the second largest economy, it has never been institutionalised," says Swali.

It was Chiuri who pointed out that in all the years she had come to Chanakya (she started visiting in the mid-1990s) all the artisans were men. "The idea came from her, and we decided to dedicate the school to women," says Swali.

Currently, the school (where no fee is charged; an honorarium is given to the students) has an 18-month programme